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Creating wide networks of support for Indigenous languages: The workshop on Community-based Language Research Across the Americas (CBLRAA)[1]

Katherine J. Riestenberg, Haverford College
Melvatha Chee, The University of New Mexico
Tania Granadillo, University of Western Ontario
Shannon Bischoff, Purdue University Fort Wayne

Introduction

Research on the Indigenous languages of the Americas increasingly aims to employ community-based approaches. The Canadian Centre for Community-based Research[2] proposes that community-based research involves the following three characteristics: 1) Community-driven: Begins with a research topic of practical relevance to the community and promotes community self-determination; 2) Participatory: Community members and researchers equitably share control of the research agenda through active and reciprocal involvement in the research design, implementation and dissemination. 3) Action-oriented: The process and results are useful to community members in making positive social change and to promote social equity.

While many in the academic community agree with these priorities in principle, community-based approaches to Indigenous language research face a number of challenges (e.g., Czaykowska-Higgins 2009; De Korne 2017; Franchetto & Rice 2014; Leonard & Haynes 2010; Penfield et al. 2008; Pérez Báez, Rogers, & Rosés Labrada 2016; Rice 2006; Stenzel 2014; Whaley 2011; Yamada 2007). Several assumptions of academic discussions surrounding community-based work simply do not hold when it comes to the actual research taking place, resulting in numerous contradictions. On the one hand, efforts towards decolonized understandings of "language" and "linguistics" are attracting new attention and support (Leonard 2017). On the other hand, changes to academic practices in response to this work are slow-moving. On the one hand, the field promotes the production of community-driven research products. On the other hand, a rigid ideology surrounding the nature of academic research products prevents the field from fully recognizing the value of non-traditional research products, especially for academic advancement such as tenure and promotion (Benedicto, 2018). On the one hand, publicly accessible digital archives are now the gold standard (e.g., Holton 2012). On the other hand, we know that Internet access is not by any means universal (e.g., Parkhurst et al. 2015) and that communities do not always want part or all of their language made publicly available. On the one hand, community-based approaches may have a greater potential to mitigate language shift in Indigenous communities (e.g., Hermes & Engman 2017; Rice 2011). On the other hand, programs that train documentary or descriptive linguists rarely include training on language teaching and learning (and vice-versa), which can leave linguists ill-equipped to truly support community needs.

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[2] https://www.communitybasedresearch.ca/our-approach (accessed August 31, 2020).

Critically, these challenges cannot be addressed without strong and diverse representation of the stakeholders involved, but there are few consistent platforms for communication about community-based Indigenous language work across geographical and sociopolitical boundaries. In the U.S. academic context these discussions have traditionally been dominated by non-Indigenous researchers, with little representation of Indigenous voices or the voices of researchers and language experts based in Latin America and the Caribbean. Because there are few consistent platforms for communication across the Americas, noteworthy work on community-based approaches to language documentation and revitalization taking place in Latin America and the Caribbean does not always reach community members and researchers based in the U.S. or Canada. A commonly held belief, supported by different publishing cultures, is that different academic communities across the Americas do not communicate with each other effectively and do not share a common understanding of the scope of available work, in part due to a bias towards English-only publishing in U.S. and Canadian academic contexts (e.g., Kamadjeu 2019). Similarly, Indigenous community members based in the U.S. and Canada rarely have opportunities to learn from the successes of community-based work taking place in Latin America.

This paper describes one effort to address the need for a wide network of support for the Indigenous languages of the Americas, the 2019 workshop on Community-based Language Research Across the Americas (CBLRAA). The workshop focused on opening communication channels for possible collaboration, improving sharing of information, and developing solutions to efficiently and appropriately conduct Indigenous language work. In this report, we describe how participants shared their experiences, insights, conceptualizations, and wishes for the future of community-based research. This report engages with questions raised by participants themselves and in contemporary literature on community-based language research, including the appropriate roles of professional linguists when working with Indigenous communities.

Goals of the workshop

The workshop took place over one and a half days just prior to the 2019 annual meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA, linguisticsociety.org) in New York City and was carried out in collaboration with the Society for Study of the Indigenous Languages of the Americas (SSILA, ssila.org) with financial support from the National Science Foundation Documenting Endangered Languages program (BCS-1833155). The workshop brought together for the first time SSILA members, Latin American scholars, members of Indigenous communities in the U.S., Canada, Latin America and the Caribbean, and members of the Indigenous Latin American diaspora (including a number of participants who fit more than one of these groups) to discuss ideas regarding community-based research. By supporting the attendance of Indigenous and Latin American researchers and community members, many of whom had not been regular attendees at SSILA, we hoped to promote an understanding of how community-based research is conceptualized across the Americas, what principles and constructs are being used, and what can be learned from one another in order to conduct language research in a more ethical and effective manner and promote language revitalization, maintenance, and documentation. The workshop was participatory in nature; there were invited presentations but also small and large group discussions, with a focus on working through issues in semi-structured discussion. The generalized reflections and observations reported here are based on the activities during the workshop as well as 22 pre-workshop surveys and 15 post-workshop surveys completed by participants. This workshop was organized by four academics with varied

experiences in North, Central, and South America and one of them also being a member of an Indigenous community.

Diverse perspectives, common issues

The CBLRAA workshop was an unprecedented gathering of diverse stakeholders working to support Indigenous languages of the Americas, with a special focus on bringing perspectives from Latin American and Caribbean contexts to interact with U.S.-based community members and academics. The invited presenters were linguists representing a range of institutions and Indigenous communities. These included Ana Carla Bruno (Instituto Nacional de Pesquisas da Amazônia and Universidade da Amazônia, Brazil); Melvatha Chee (Navajo Nation and University of Alberta); Marleen Haboud (Pontificia Universidad Católica, Ecuador); Daniel Kaufman (Endangered Language Alliance and Queens College) with Leobardo Ajtzalam (K'iche'), Jackeline Alvarez (Mixtec), and Alexis Paz (P'urhépecha); Wesley Leonard (Miami Tribe of Oklahoma and University of California Riverside); Eladio (B'alam) Mateo Toledo (Centro de Investigaciones y Estudios Superiores en Antropología Social, Unidad Sureste, Mexico); and Carlos Sánchez Avendaño (Universidad de Costa Rica). The workshop also financially supported the attendance of nine Indigenous community members working on language documentation, maintenance, revitalization, or reclamation in their communities. More than 30 additional participants joined the workshop each day. Figure 1 shows the languages represented at the workshop and the approximate locations where they are traditionally spoken. The list includes languages represented by community members as well as languages which outsider linguists are working to support.



Figure 1. Languages CBLRAA participants are working to support

Participants shared a range of definitions of community-based research before, during, and after the workshop. Most participants saw community-based language research (CBLR) as research driven by the needs and wishes of the community and conducted in continuous consultation with the community. However, some offered more specific definitions. A few participants said that CBLR must result in practical or applied outcomes or benefits for the community or retained in the community. One participant defined CBLR as "multi-generational work." During a workshop exercise that asked participants to imagine beginning a new language documentation project, some participants critiqued the way outsider linguists have sometimes approached working with communities, stating that the linguist "shouldn't come in to save" the language, and that outsiders should not act as teachers who are only there to train community members. Other participants saw the role of outsider linguists as mainly offering tools or helping guide a project. Several participants reported after the workshop that their participation reinforced their original definitions of CBLR, but a few participants began to challenge or deconstruct the notion of CBLR. For example, one participant called into question the notion of "community," asking, "Do we consider every member of the group being studied? Just the speakers? Just the Indigenous leaders?" Another participant pointed out the heterogeneity within Indigenous communities, especially those located in urban areas. The understanding that communities are in many ways not monolithic entities was a recurring theme of the workshop. Other participants commented on differences in the historical context leading to language loss in different communities. One participant stated, "I was aware that the political/historical context of colonization was different in the U.S., Canada, and Latin America, but it was really highlighted for me during the workshop. The differences do have a big impact on what community-based work looks like in the different communities, and that's an important awareness to have."

Participants also differed in the specific goals and challenges they reported. One major difference was that some participants were working in contexts where there are fluent speakers of the language, while in other contexts there are no longer fluent speakers. Participants discussed how these differences affect their strategies and goals. Some participants stated that a major goal was to challenge the status quo of linguistic research in academia, while other participants' goals were more focused on continuing or expanding the community-language work they were already engaged in. Some participants reported that having a standardized or normalized writing system was a priority and was or could be extremely beneficial to revitalization efforts, while others saw this as unnecessary or not a major priority. Some participants saw schools as a fruitful locus of revitalization efforts through language teaching, while others expressed that they did not feel schools were where efforts should be focused, and that revitalization should focus on re-establishing the use of the language in the home and in various social settings. Some participants saw traditional linguistic analysis as extremely pertinent and useful to their goals, while others felt that these approaches often obscured or failed to represent Indigenous knowledge and conceptualizations of language.

At the same time, participants reported on a number of similarities in terms of their broader challenges. As one participant noted, "On the whole continent we are still fighting against colonial impositions that hinder work supporting the wellbeing of Indigenous peoples and the sustainability of Indigenous languages."[3] Another participant stated, "The power of the dominant group (colonizer) always has insidious ways of impeding the progress/advancement of

[3] Original Spanish: "En todo el continente seguimos batallando imposiciones coloniales que lastima el trabajo en apoyo al bienestar de los pueblos y a la sustentabilidad de las lenguas de estas."

projects."[4] Many participants lamented the lack of resources to carry out their goals, with many noting they did not have enough time to do what they wanted to do. As one participant noted in a breakout session, "There are never enough resources. How do we make the most of the time/money/people who are committed to language documentation and revitalization?" Other participants pointed to a gap between the funding available and the community language work that is needed. In response to a question about what would be needed to implement their ideas for CBLR, one participant responded, "Funding agencies that are conscious and understanding of community needs that are not currently thought of as central to a linguistic/scientific enterprise." Many participants agreed that there is a mismatch in priorities and incentives between academic language work and community language work, with several participants suggesting that community-focused products of academic research should be valued as highly as peer-reviewed academic papers. Relatedly, there was some discussion of the ethics and practicalities of encouraging young Indigenous community members to train as academic linguists when such mismatches abound.

In sum, while all participants in the CBLRAA workshop shared in common involvement in community-based work to support Indigenous languages of the Americas, being together in this space made it clear that each participant had a unique situation and perspective. This workshop allowed participants an opportunity to share ideas and goals, compare situations and challenges, and express concerns involving linguistic research work in Indigenous communities.

The multilingual approach

A unique aspect of the CBLRAA workshop was its focus on connecting people from across geographic and sociopolitical boundaries with the common goal of supporting the Indigenous languages of the Americas. To do this, it was necessary to operate as a multilingual event, with workshop materials, discussions, and surveys available in at least one language every participant was comfortable with. Based on the participants who registered for the workshop, this meant aiming to make workshop content available in three common languages: Spanish, Portuguese, and English.

This commitment to holding a multilingual workshop resulted in a number of challenges. The most overt challenge was the time involved in translating. This included the time on the part of the workshop organizers to translate the workshop application materials, website, surveys, and all informational emails into the three languages. In consideration of the time involved in translating, as well as limited space and funding for multiple projectors, it was decided that workshop presentation materials prepared by invited speakers should be available in two languages, one being either Spanish or Portuguese and the other being English, with the understanding that Spanish-readers could comprehend the majority of Portuguese text and vice-versa. The multilingual approach also meant incorporating different strategies for small and large group discussions, in hopes of creating a space where every participant could engage with these activities. In some cases, participants divided into small groups based on shared languages (an English group, a Portuguese group, a Spanish group, and a Spanish-English group). While this approach had the benefit of not requiring translations within groups, participants felt that this reinforced the geographical and sociopolitical boundaries that we were hoping to reach across. Therefore, subsequent small groups were formed based on discussion themes, with participants finding strategies to informally translate within their groups as needed, relying on the

[4] Original Spanish: "El poder del grupo dominante (colonizer) siempre tiene maneras insidiosas de impedir la conservación y el progreso/avance de los proyectos."

multilingual skills of individual participants. As one participant explained, "I think that the way of forming discussion groups the second day (by similar interests) worked better. For convenience, it would seem that [grouping by] language is a better option, but that—in my experience—ended up not being the case. The second day I was able to share with people from Surinam, for example, and that was a very enriching experience for me."[5]

Although the multilingual approach presented challenges, it also resulted in a number of benefits reported by participants, some of which were not anticipated by the workshop organizers. For instance, the on-the-spot translations offered by workshop organizers, participants, and discussion chairs during full-group discussions seemed to emerge as a form of highlighting what was important in the discussion. Sometimes participants stopped and waited for or requested a translation, and at other times participants translated their own contributions. The handling or transference of which information needed to be translated emerged from the participants themselves. In this sense, the multilingual approach was realized in a way that modeled a community-based and community led workshop. One participant reported their enthusiasm about the approach, saying, "I found the multilingualism of the conference absolutely wonderful. I feel like it was able to tie different communities together towards common goals and made the world a whole lot smaller." Other participants offered suggestions for how to improve this approach in the future, with more deliberate mixing and matching of different language groups.

Wide networks of support for Indigenous languages

As previously stated, the overarching goal of the CBLRAA workshop was to provide an initial platform for communication among community members, researchers, and institutions across the Americas who engage in community-based language work. Because this was the first time organizers had developed a workshop of its kind, it was decided to focus on emergent outcomes, that is, allowing space for workshop goals and outcomes to emerge from participants themselves rather than establishing these *a priori*.

Through the workshop activities and surveys, participants reiterated the need for wide networks of support for Indigenous languages, sharing their ideas about what we can learn from one another. Many participants felt that learning about other community-based projects was one of the most valuable aspects of the workshop, and they underscored a desire for more spaces for Indigenous community members working on language revitalization to interact with one another, sometimes without non-Indigenous researchers present, with one participant stating that alliances between Indigenous peoples would be vital. Some expressed frustration that the efforts they have been involved with have not been successful in terms of creating new speakers and felt that learning from other communities about what has worked, especially from an Indigenous knowledge perspective, would be valuable. One participant stated the need to "support each other in all ways: share resources, share stories, share emotional support, share small experiences that are not evident or in the spotlight, gain perspective through the sharing of diverse situations and experiences with a common goal."

When asked to reflect on what we could achieve together that we would not be able to achieve apart, some participants said that, in addition to sharing experiences and offering moral

[5] Original Spanish: "Creo que funcionó mejor la forma cómo se conformaron los grupos de discusión el segundo día (por afinidad temática). Por facilidad, pareciera que la mejor opción es por lengua, pero ello -en mi experiencia- resultó engañoso. El segundo día pude compartir con gente de Surinam, por ejemplo, y ello representó una experiencia sumamente enriquecedora para mí."

support, we can also create stronger movements for social and academic change. One participant pointed to the need to "collectively support the change of society's negative attitudes about Indigenous languages globally." Some participants felt that it could be useful to come together to create an ideal model of documentation and revitalization that would be applicable across the diversity and differences of Indigenous languages of the Americas. However, others felt that this was unnecessary and could be counter-productive. As one participant stated, "There are no recipes or models…some easily make the error of 'universalist' thinking, when in reality each community, each movement, and each project is unique."

Participants also offered ideas for ways to continue forward after this initial workshop. Many felt that some sort of continuation was needed, either online, in person, or both. One participant suggested "parallel smaller workshops in different locations followed by a larger workshop that brings everyone together again." Another suggested "regular scheduled times for communication (online or otherwise) to share ideas, stories, and to brainstorm." Other suggested follow-up workshops not necessarily tied to the LSA/SSILA meetings, perhaps in locations in Latin America or in an Indigenous community. Many suggested using technology such as a social network group and email list to stay in touch, and these groups were subsequently created.

When asked to rate on a scale of 1-10 how much they would like to see certain follow-up activities realized, all 15 participants who filled out the post-workshop survey ranked "Sustained funding to bring diverse participants to the annual LSA/SSILA meetings" as a 10. Others priorities were "Communication networks that better connect community members to institutions," with an average rating of 9.5, and "Appeals to U.S.-based publishers to support multi-version publishing and publishing in languages other than English," with an average rating of 9.4. Reinforcing the misalignment with academic priorities, the lowest ranked activity was "A multilingual edited volume showcasing the work of workshop participants," with an average rating of 8.3.

One clear theme that emerged from discussions of continued activities was a desire for spaces and communication networks that better connect community members to other community members. One participant suggested a workshop for only Indigenous community members, and another suggested more participation of elders. On the other hand, some participants worried that by holding a workshop on CBLR among people already engaged in CBLR, we were "only talking to each other," and that we did not need to convince like-minded individuals of the importance of community-driven work. Participants wondered how we could better reach linguists and researchers who have not yet made community-driven work a priority.

Conclusion

Organizers and participants of the CBLRAA 2019 workshop were not sure how things would unfold. Reflecting on the workshop after the fact, one thing is quite clear: Indigenous community members valued the multilingual space created and the opportunity to come together with other community members and academic scholars to discuss issues of language documentation, sustainability, and revival across the Americas. At the same time, the workshop showed that perhaps our construction of community-based research as defined above and construed by the organizers misses the fact that there are community-to-community relationships and partnerships that do not include an "academic researcher-community" relationship, and that this must be taken into account when trying to understand the complexities of "community" work and partnerships. Workshop organizers and presenters realized they have the resources to facilitate future gatherings and to serve as true partners. Many workshop participants

reconnected at the UNESCO International Year of Indigenous Languages Perspectives Conference where there were dedicated spaces for community members from all over the world to interact with one another.

CBLRAA provided an opportunity to connect people from various backgrounds who are working to support the great variety of Indigenous languages of the Americas. The experience reiterated that every situation is unique. None of the participants had the same exact situation, but at the same time, many participants faced similar challenges. Being in the same room allowed us to better identify and articulate these challenges as well as identify with one another. The IYIL Perspectives conference, and in turn this proceedings volume, was in many ways a direct outcome of the CBLRAA workshop. In part because Shannon Bischoff was an organizer of both events, it was possible to apply insights from the CBLRAA workshop to the shaping and planning of the IYIL Perspectives conference. The conference made an effort to apply an inclusive design and give primacy to Indigenous voices at an event about five times the size of the original workshop. We hope that future efforts can continue to draw on this foundation as an established network to address these challenges and advocate for our common values in the spaces we each occupy.

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